Diesel pickup (towing) maintenance schedule

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For 3/4- and 1-ton diesel pickups that pull equipment trailers: Ford Super Duty Power Stroke, Ram Cummins and GM Duramax. All three makers put a towing truck on the severe schedule, and all three count idle time against oil life.

Typical intervals from manufacturer manuals and published service schedules. Your truck's manual and its oil-life monitor come first.

Every fuel stop or tow

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Check DEF level	Every fuel stop		
Check engine oil	Every fuel stop on a hard-working truck	Warm engine, level ground, wait after shutoff	
Look over the gooseneck or 5th-wheel hitch	Before each tow	Cracks, pins in, safety chain loops intact	

Monthly

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Drain the fuel water separator	Monthly	Right away if the water-in-fuel light comes on	
Batteries, coolant, brake and transmission fluid levels	Monthly		
Hitch bolt torque	Regularly	Values vary by hitch; check your hitch manual	

Oil and filters

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Engine oil and filter, normal	7,500 to 15,000 miles or yearly	Or when the oil-life monitor says; varies by make	
Engine oil and filter, towing	Sooner, per the oil-life monitor or severe schedule	Ram: never past 500 engine hours	
Idle and PTO time	Counts against oil life	1 hour of idle is about 25 to 33 miles	
Fuel filters	Per your manual	Ford: every other oil change when towing. GM: 22,500 miles or 2 years	
Engine air filter	Per the filter gauge or monitor	Ram: no longer than 30,000 miles	

Longer

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Transmission, transfer case and axle fluids	Per your manual's severe schedule	Towing shortens these a lot, often to 50,000 to 60,000 miles	
Coolant	Per your manual	Often 100,000 to 150,000 miles for the first change	

DPF (exhaust filter)

TASK	HOW OFTEN	NOTES	✓
Let regeneration finish	When the message shows	Steady highway driving for up to about 30 minutes	
Park away from dry grass during or right after a regen	Every time	The exhaust gets hot enough to start a fire	

Service log: diesel pickup (towing)

Machine / unit: _____ Make & model: _____

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DATE	MILES / HOURS	WORK DONE	PARTS USED	INITIALS